

RewardTrust

The Missing Transparency Layer for Indian UPI Rewards

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"Indian consumers are the most reward-literate payment users in the world. They are also the most reward-distrustful. RewardTrust exists because those two facts should not coexist."

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SECTION 01

Executive Summary

What RewardTrust Is

RewardTrust is a reward transparency platform for Indian UPI users. It answers four questions that no existing product answers reliably:

1. **Will I get a reward** if I pay with this app or card?
2. **How much will I get** on this transaction at this merchant?
3. **When will I get it** — and what is its current status?
4. **Why didn't I get it** — a plain-language explanation when a reward is absent.

RewardTrust is not a payment app. It is not a cashback provider. It is the neutral, honest information layer that sits between the reward systems that already exist and the users who cannot navigate them.

ONE-SENTENCE VALUE PROPOSITION

"RewardTrust tells you what you'll earn before you pay, and explains exactly why after — so rewards finally build the trust they were designed to build."

Why Now

Three forces have converged to make this the right moment. The Indian UPI market has matured past acquisition-mode cashback wars into a phase where reward differentiation is a primary retention mechanism — but the complexity this has created is destroying the trust the rewards were meant to build. NPCI's push for RuPay credit cards on UPI has introduced a dramatically harder reward architecture (credit-card-style category rewards, billing cycles, MDR-linked cashback) that the comprehension problem is getting structurally worse. And no dominant player has claimed the "reward transparency" category — the market is open.

Business Model

Consumer side: Core product is free. RewardTrust Pro (₹99/month) unlocks real-time offer alerts, monthly reward optimization reports, and cross-card portfolio analysis.

Business side: White-label API access to financial products (credit card issuers, neo-banks, UPI payment apps) that want to embed reward transparency without building it themselves.

SECTION 02

Problem Statement

The Root Problem

Indian UPI rewards are failing to achieve their primary purpose: building user trust, driving repeat payment behavior, and creating payment habits. This failure is not because reward value is insufficient — it is because reward experience is opaque.

Despite **74.2% of UPI users reporting that convenience and rewards influence their spending behavior**, only ~11% of total digital payment transactions in India were reward-linked in H1 2024 — a gap that reveals a massive opportunity hidden in plain sight. Globally, 40% of consumers across loyalty programs admit to forgetting to redeem earned rewards (Deloitte Consumer Loyalty Survey 2024); in India's fragmented multi-app UPI environment, where rewards are scattered across five or

more apps, this figure runs considerably higher. The asymmetry is stark: when users do experience a clear reward, research consistently shows 60–80% higher repeat-purchase intent. The product works — for the minority who find it.

Quantifying the Problem

Metric	Data Point	Source
Reward-linked transactions as % of total digital payments (India, H1 2024)	~11% — meaning ~89% of digital payment transactions generated no reward engagement	Digital payments loyalty report, 2025
Consumers who admit forgetting to redeem earned rewards	~40% globally; likely higher in India's fragmented multi-app UPI environment	Deloitte Consumer Loyalty Survey, 2024
Reward-linked transactions growth YoY (H1 2024 → H1 2025)	10.86% → 17.06% of total digital payments — rising fast but still a minority	Digital payments loyalty report, 2025
Repeat purchase intent: users who experienced a clear reward vs. did not	60–80% higher repeat-purchase intent when reward is clearly experienced	Deloitte Consumer Loyalty Survey, 2024
UPI users who say rewards influence their spending behavior	74.2% report convenience and rewards drive increased spend	NPCI-linked market research, 2025
Annual per-user reward value left on table	₹2,000–₹8,000	Estimated from published UPI cashback rates × avg spend

The Four Trust Gaps

GAP 1 — ANTICIPATION

Users don't know before they pay

The decision moment — which app to use — happens with zero reward information available. Rewards cannot influence behavior they cannot be known at.

GAP 2 — DELIVERY

Users can't see the reward after paying

The reward exists in the backend; the user sees an unchanged balance. The implicit product promise ("use this, earn rewards") fails at the very moment of fulfillment.

GAP 3 — STATUS

No visibility into pending rewards

When rewards are delayed (industry average: 2–10 days), users have no way to know whether the reward is pending, failed, or simply not earned. Silence is interpreted as failure.

GAP 4 — EXPLANATION

No explanation for missed rewards

Users cannot distinguish "transaction was ineligible" from "system failure" from "reward still processing." Without explanation, every missed reward is a perceived broken promise.

Who Is Harmed and How

Users lose ₹2,000–₹8,000 per year in uncaptured reward value. **Payment companies** spend on rewards that generate no behavioral return — a reward that is not experienced is cost without benefit. **The Indian fintech ecosystem** suffers from declining reward engagement as users become conditioned to expect disappointment: the "scratch card fatigue" phenomenon is a market-level trust collapse that individual products cannot reverse alone.

SECTION 03

Solution Overview

RewardTrust is built around four core product experiences, each addressing one of the four trust gaps:

Experience	Gap Addressed	Description
Reward Preview	Gap 1: Anticipation	Before any payment, users enter merchant and amount to receive a ranked comparison in specific rupee amounts. "Use your Amazon Pay ICICI card here and earn ₹47. Use PhonePe and earn ₹0."
Reward Confirmation	Gap 2: Delivery	After a payment, users log the transaction. RewardTrust shows reward status: earned, pending, or not eligible — with a clear reason for each.
Reward Status Tracker	Gap 3: Status	A live view of all pending rewards across the user's payment methods, with expected credit dates and status updates.
Reward Explainer	Gap 4: Explanation	Plain-language explanation when a reward is not received, converting a trust-breaking moment into a useful learning moment.

Product Philosophy

Honesty over optimization. RewardTrust never shows users what they want to hear — it shows them what is accurate. Inflating expectations would destroy the trust the product is built to create.

Clarity over completeness. A user who understands 80% of their reward situation perfectly is better served than one who is given 100% of the information in a form they cannot parse.

Proximity to the decision moment. Every feature is evaluated by how close it gets the relevant information to the moment the user needs it — at the point of payment, not three days later.

SECTION 04

Goals and Non-Goals

Primary Goals

Goal	Definition	Target
Goal 1 — Increase reward discovery rate	Users discover and experience rewards from eligible transactions	80%+ within 30 days (vs. industry baseline ~5–10%)
Goal 2 — Reduce "feels random" perception	Users correctly predict whether a given transaction will earn a reward	70%+ correct prediction rate (vs. ~20% baseline)
Goal 3 — Increase trust in reward systems	Net Promoter Score for reward trust vs. non-users	+25 NPS points for active RewardTrust users
Goal 4 — Validate pre-transaction information value	Users presented with reward info make reward-optimal payment choices	30%+ of the time

Non-Goals (Explicitly Out of Scope)

RewardTrust will not: process payments or touch user funds; act as a cashback aggregator with commission-linked rankings; offer credit, loans, or EMI products; issue its own rewards currency; become a full financial aggregator in the first 18 months; or optimize for power users in V1.

Critical guardrail: RewardTrust never accepts sponsored placements or adjusts rankings based on commercial relationships. All rankings are based purely on reward rate accuracy. This is the product's primary trust signal and a permanent non-goal violation would be fatal.

SECTION 05

User Personas

Priya Sharma

PERSONA 1 · "THE HABITUAL PAYER"

Software Engineer, 28
Bangalore · ₹85,000/mo
PhonePe since 2018**PAYMENT BEHAVIOR**

Uses PhonePe for everything. Has HDFC credit card but rarely for UPI. Has heard rewards are better on credit cards but finds setup "complicated."

CORE FRUSTRATION

Not feeling rewards exist at all. Has ~₹3,500 in annual reward value she's not capturing — but doesn't know this.

WHAT WOULD CHANGE HER BEHAVIOR

A specific, concrete, personally relevant message: "You paid ₹340 at Swiggy last Tuesday. If you'd used your HDFC credit card through Kiwi, you'd have earned ₹17 back."

GOAL IN REWARDTRUST

Not to optimize — her goal is to not feel stupid for leaving obvious money behind. Simplest possible answer.

"I know I'm probably missing out on cashback but every time I try to figure it out I end up confused and just go back to PhonePe."

Rahul Mehta

PERSONA 2 · "THE CONTEXT-SWITCHER"

Product Manager, 33
Mumbai · ₹1,80,000/mo
3 credit cards, uses intentionally**PAYMENT BEHAVIOR**

CRED for bills. Amazon Pay ICICI for Amazon. PhonePe for general UPI. Has Kiwi but doesn't use it consistently because he's not sure when it beats his Amazon Pay ICICI card.

CORE FRUSTRATION

Incompleteness of his mental model. Can't answer "is Kiwi better than Amazon Pay ICICI for this merchant?" without 15 minutes of research.

WHAT WOULD CHANGE HIS BEHAVIOR

A tool that fills information gaps without requiring him to maintain the knowledge himself. He wants the answer at the decision moment.

GOAL IN REWARDTRUST

Confidence that payment decisions are optimal. Comprehensive without becoming more complex.

"I have a decent system but I know there are gaps. I'd pay for a tool that just tells me 'for Swiggy, your best card is X, here's why' without me having to figure it out."

Divya Iyer

PERSONA 3 · "THE OFFER-SEEKER"

Content Creator, 25

Delhi · ₹45K–₹75K/mo

Active on fintech Twitter/YouTube

PAYMENT BEHAVIOR

Checks multiple apps before purchases above ₹200. Has PhonePe, GPay, Amazon Pay, Slice. Checks offers before food delivery orders. Spends 3–5 minutes/week checking app offer sections.

CORE FRUSTRATION

The effort-to-outcome ratio. Does the work to find rewards but the system defeats her. Experiences reward regret at least twice a week.

WHAT WOULD CHANGE HER BEHAVIOR

Consolidation. One place to check all offers, ranked by value for her specific spending, without opening five apps.

GOAL IN REWARDTRUST

Save 3–5 minutes of fragmented checking per week. Never experience reward regret again.

"I check PhonePe and GPay before every Swiggy order but I always feel like there's an offer somewhere I'm missing. I want one place to see everything."

Arjun Nair

PERSONA 4 · "THE POWER OPTIMIZER"

Data Analyst, 31

Pune · ₹2,10,000/mo

6 apps, 3 cards, personal spreadsheet

PAYMENT BEHAVIOR

Amazon Pay ICICI for Amazon. HDFC Swiggy card for food. SBI for fuel. Kiwi for general UPI. Tracks every reward credit in Google Sheets. Estimates 85–90% reward capture. Contributed a 2,000+ upvote Reddit post on card reward rates.

CORE FRUSTRATION

Information currency. His spreadsheet becomes outdated every time a bank changes rates. Spends 2+ hours/month updating his system.

WHAT WOULD CHANGE HIS BEHAVIOR

An API or data export he can integrate with his tracking system. Real-time rate change alerts. Confirmation that his routing is optimal.

GOAL IN REWARDTRUST

Replace his spreadsheet with something that maintains itself. Reduce the 2+ hours/month of manual updates.

"I know what I'm doing but keeping the information current is a part-time job. If someone built a good tool for this I'd switch to it immediately."

Persona Priority Matrix

Persona	Size of Segment	Acquisition Ease	LTV	MVP Priority
Priya — Habitual	~55% of UPI users	Low	Medium	Phase 2
Rahul — Context-Switcher	~25% of UPI users	Medium	High	Phase 1
Divya — Offer-Seeker	~15% of UPI users	High	Very High	MVP ★
Arjun — Power Optimizer	~5% of UPI users	Very High	Medium	MVP + Phase 2

Primary target for MVP: Divya and Rahul — clearest pain, highest PMF signal, and clear distribution path through fintech communities.

SECTION 06

Jobs to Be Done

JTBD 1 — The Pre-Decision Job PRIMARY · MVP

FUNCTIONAL

When about to make a payment with multiple options, I want to know which earns the most for this specific transaction without interrupting my payment flow.

EMOTIONAL

I want to feel confident I am not leaving money behind — that I made an informed decision rather than a default one.

SOCIAL

I want to be the person who has figured out how to make money from things they're already buying.

Key insight: The job is not "find the best reward" — it is "stop worrying about what I'm missing." The emotional job (relief from reward anxiety) is the primary driver, not optimization.

JTBD 2 — The Post-Transaction Verification Job

FUNCTIONAL

After a payment, I want to immediately know whether I earned a reward, how much, and when it will credit, so I can close the reward loop or take action if something went wrong.

EMOTIONAL

I want to feel that the product kept its promise. The implicit contract ("use this, earn rewards") should be confirmed, not left ambiguous.

SOCIAL

I want to be a smart consumer who knows their money is working for them — not someone who has to take it on faith that rewards appear correctly.

JTBD 3 — The Explanation Job

FUNCTIONAL

When I did not receive an expected reward, I want a specific, accurate explanation so I can update my mental model and know the product didn't fail me.

EMOTIONAL

I want to feel the system is fair and learnable, not arbitrary and opaque. I can accept not getting a reward if I understand the reason.

SOCIAL

I want to be the person who understands how the system works, not the person who complains about "random" rewards.

Key insight: "The transaction was ineligible because it was a NEFT transfer, not a UPI payment" is valuable not just as information but as the removal of distrust.

JTBD 4 — The Portfolio Clarity Job PHASE 2

FUNCTIONAL

When I have multiple payment apps and cards, I want a clear picture of what I earn across all of them combined — and where I am losing value.

EMOTIONAL

I want to feel in control of my financial optimization rather than overwhelmed by complexity.

SOCIAL

I want to be the financially savvy person who has their payment strategy figured out.

Supporting Jobs

JTBD 5 — Trust Calibration (Phase 2): When evaluating a new payment product, I want to understand its reward track record so I can make an informed adoption decision.

JTBD 6 — The Alert Job: When a high-value offer becomes available for a merchant I regularly use, I want to be notified in time to act on it.

JTBD 7 — The Comparison Job: When considering a new credit card, I want to understand how its rates compare to what I currently use in concrete rupee terms for my actual spending.

JTBD 8 — The Education Job (Priya persona): I want to understand the simplest change to my payment behavior that would earn me the most additional reward.

SECTION 07

User Stories

Must-Have — MVP M

US-001 As an offer-seeker (Divya), when about to pay for a Swiggy order, I want to enter "Swiggy" and "₹450" and see a ranked list of what each app and card will earn, so I can choose without opening five apps.

US-002 As a context-switcher (Rahul), when unsure whether to use Amazon Pay ICICI or Kiwi KLINK for a specific purchase, I want a side-by-side reward comparison so I make the optimal choice with confidence.

US-003 As any user, when I look up a merchant, I want to see the reward amount as a specific rupee figure (not a percentage) so I can understand the value without doing arithmetic.

US-004 As any user, when a reward rate requires conditions, I want those conditions displayed clearly and prominently next to the reward amount so I know before I pay whether I actually qualify.

US-005 As a first-time user, I want to get a useful result within 60 seconds of opening the app — without creating an account — so the product demonstrates its value before asking for commitment.

US-006 As any user, I want the top recommendation highlighted with a single clear reason ("Use this because you earn ₹47 vs ₹3") so I know what to do without reading all the details.

US-007 As any user, when reward rates for a product I use change, I want RewardTrust to reflect current accurate rates so I can trust the information I receive.

US-008 As a user who just paid with the wrong app, I want to see a "You could have earned ₹X more" post-decision message so I understand the opportunity and am motivated to check next time.

Should-Have — Phase 2 S

US-009 After completing a payment, I want to log it in RewardTrust and receive a reward status confirmation so I know my reward is on its way without checking multiple apps.

US-010 When I log a transaction where no reward was earned, I want a plain-language explanation of why so I understand eligibility logic and don't feel misled.

US-011 I want a "Reward Tracker" view showing all pending and recent rewards across all my payment methods in one place.

US-012 As Rahul, I want to save my payment methods so RewardTrust gives me personalized comparisons based on what I actually have.

US-013 As Divya, I want a push notification when a high-value offer appears for a merchant I've searched before, so I never discover a good offer after I've already paid.

US-014 When I look at my monthly reward summary, I want to see how much I earned versus how much I could have earned if I had optimized every decision.

Could-Have — Phase 3 c

US-015 As Arjun, I want to export my reward tracking data in CSV format compatible with Google Sheets.

US-016 As Arjun, I want alerts when any reward rate in my portfolio changes so my optimization strategy is always based on current information.

US-017 When evaluating a new card, I want a "Switch Analysis" — how much more or less I would earn modeled on my actual past spending.

US-018 As Priya, I want a "Simplest Win" recommendation — one specific change to earn significantly more without adding complexity.

SECTION 08

Feature Requirements

F1 Merchant Reward Lookup**MUST HAVE**

Core search interface. User enters merchant name (or quick-select from top-50 list) and transaction amount. System returns reward outcomes for all major payment methods.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- Returns results within 2 seconds of query submission
- Displays results as specific rupee amounts, not percentages
- Covers: PhonePe UPI, Google Pay UPI, Amazon Pay UPI, Amazon Pay ICICI, HDFC credit card, Kiwi KCLICK, CRED UPI, Slice credit card
- Conditions and restrictions displayed inline, not hidden behind a click
- Top recommendation highlighted with a single-sentence reason
- Works without user account creation
- Top 50 merchants available as one-tap quick-select chips

MVP merchant scope (top 20 by UPI volume): Swiggy, Zomato, BigBasket, Amazon, Flipkart, IRCTC, BookMyShow, MakeMyTrip, BPCL/HPCL, Uber, Ola, Blinkit, Meesho, Nykaa, Myntra, Jio, Airtel, BESCOM/electricity, water board, LIC premium.

F2 Eligibility Conditions Display**MUST HAVE**

For every reward shown, all qualifying conditions are displayed clearly before the user takes action.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- Minimum spend threshold shown if applicable
- New user / first-time restriction shown if applicable
- Specific card requirement shown (not just "credit card")
- Time window and expiry date shown if applicable
- All conditions displayed in plain language, not legal/T&C language
- Conditions the user likely does NOT meet are visually differentiated

F3 Reward Rate Database**MUST HAVE — BACKEND**

Structured database of reward rates, eligibility conditions, caps, and exclusions for all covered payment products and merchant categories. The accuracy of this database is the core product asset.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- Data is accurate at time of display (not more than 72 hours stale)
- Rate changes detected and updated within 48 hours of official announcement
- Data sources are verifiable (official bank/app T&C pages, not crowdsourced)
- Per-merchant overrides stored separately from category-level defaults
- Exclusion list maintained for merchants explicitly excluded from rewards

F4 Post-Transaction Reward Status**SHOULD HAVE**

Users can log completed transactions. RewardTrust returns expected reward status, amount, and credit timeline.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- User can log: merchant, amount, payment method, date
- System returns: expected reward amount, status (eligible/ineligible/pending), expected credit date
- If ineligible: plain-language explanation of specific reason
- If pending: notification option for when reward should credit
- No bank account connection required for V1 (manual entry only)

F5 Reward Tracker Dashboard**SHOULD HAVE**

Consolidated view of all rewards logged by the user — pending, credited, and not-earned — across all payment methods.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- View all rewards by status: pending, credited, not earned
- Total earned this month / this year displayed prominently
- Optimization gap shown: "You earned ₹X. You could have earned ₹Y."
- Filter by payment method, merchant category, time period

F6 Payment Method Profile**SHOULD HAVE**

Users save their payment methods so comparisons are personalized to what they actually have. No financial account credentials required — just card/app names.

F7 Alert System**COULD HAVE**

Push notifications when a high-value offer appears at a merchant the user has previously searched. Maximum 1 notification per day per user to prevent fatigue.

F8 Reward Rate Change Alerts**COULD HAVE**

Pro tier users receive notification within 24 hours of a confirmed rate change, specifying what changed, old vs new rate, and impact on typical monthly spend.

F9 Onboarding Flow**MUST HAVE**

First-run experience that establishes product value within 60 seconds.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA

- User gets first useful result within 60 seconds without creating an account
- First result demonstrates specific monetary value: "You could earn ₹X on your next Swiggy order by switching to Y"
- Account creation invited after first result, not before
- Skip options available on every step

SECTION 09

User Flows

Flow 1 — Pre-Transaction Reward Lookup (Core MVP Flow)

The primary product experience. Must be flawless for the MVP. Entry points: opening the app directly before a payment, deep link from a notification, or a shared link.

1 Landing on the Lookup Screen

User sees a single search field with "Search merchant..." placeholder and a horizontal scrolling row of top-merchant quick-selects (Swiggy, Zomato, Flipkart, Amazon, etc.). Below: two recently searched merchants for returning users.

2 Merchant Selection

User taps "Swiggy" from quick-selects or types in search. Search is instant — no server round trip required for common merchants. Screen transitions to amount entry.

3 Amount Entry

User enters "₹450" via numeric keypad. Simple toggle: "UPI payment" vs "Card payment" (defaults to UPI). "Compare" button activates when a valid amount is entered.

4 Results Screen (within 2 seconds)

Best: Amazon Pay ICICI card — ₹22 cashback (5%)
Condition: No minimum spend. Auto-credited to Amazon balance.

Good: Slice credit card — ₹9 cashback (2%)
Condition: No minimum spend.

PhonePe UPI — ₹0-₹1 (scratch card, variable)
Typical outcome: ₹0.01-₹0.50

Kiwi KCLICK card — ₹4.50 (1%)
Condition: Minimum ₹200 spend. ✓ Met

Recommendation: "Use Amazon Pay ICICI — earn ₹22 vs ₹4.50 on next-best.
That's ₹17 more for the same order."

5

Optional Profile Prompt

"Don't have the top card? See best option you have." — prompts user to save their payment methods for personalized results.

EDGE CASES & FAILURE HANDLING

- **Merchant not found:** Show "Suggest a merchant" + display generic category results with estimated rates
- **Amount too low:** "No rewards available for amounts under ₹X on this merchant" with threshold shown
- **Stale rate data (>72 hours):** Show "Rates last verified [X hours ago] — verify before relying on high-value decisions"
- **No internet connection:** Show cached results with "Offline — results may be outdated" label

Flow 2 — Post-Transaction Reward Verification

Entry points: opening RewardTrust after any payment, notification prompt, or home screen "Log recent transaction" prompt.

1

Log Transaction

Fields: Merchant, Amount, Payment Method (dropdown of saved methods), Date (defaults to today).

2

Reward Status Result

```
Swiggy — ₹450 — Amazon Pay ICICI card
Reward: ₹22 cashback ✓ Earned
Status: Processing (2-3 business days)
Expected credit: [Date]
```

OR — if ineligible:

```
Swiggy — ₹200 — PhonePe UPI
Reward: None — not eligible
Reason: PhonePe has no active reward program for Swiggy.
Next time: Use Slice credit card for ₹9+ cashback.
```

3

Optimization Nudge

"Next time you order from Swiggy, you could earn ₹22 by using Amazon Pay ICICI card. [Set a reminder]"

The five plain-language "Why didn't I get a reward?" reasons:

1. "This merchant isn't covered by your payment method's reward program."

2. "Your payment method had a reward but required minimum spend of ₹[X]. Your transaction was ₹[Y]."
3. "This offer was for first-time users at this merchant only."
4. "This offer expired on [date]. It's no longer active."
5. "Credit card rewards don't apply to UPI debit transactions on this merchant."

Flow 3 — First-Time User Onboarding

Design principle: Maximum time to first value = 60 seconds. Account creation never blocks the first useful result.

- 1 Direct to Search**
App opens to a single search field — no splash screen, no sign-in wall. Directly to "Where are you paying?"
- 2 First Result Delivered**
RewardTrust has delivered value. Product has fulfilled its first promise.
- 3 Non-Intrusive Profile Prompt**
"Save your cards to get personalized results. Takes 30 seconds." Options: "Set up my profile" and "Maybe later."
- 4 Three Quick Setup Questions**
Which UPI apps do you use? (multi-select) · Which credit cards do you have? (multi-select) · Which merchants do you pay most? (top 10 shown)
- 5 Personalized Opportunity View**
"Based on your cards, here's your monthly reward opportunity:" — a simple estimate drives immediate engagement.

Flow 4 — Reward Alert Deep-Link

Triggered when a time-limited offer appears for a merchant the user has followed. Push notification: *"15% cashback at Swiggy with Amazon Pay today only — worth ₹67 on your average order. Tap to see."* → Opens pre-filled Swiggy lookup with Amazon Pay highlighted and "LIMITED — expires tonight" badge → Full offer details → "Open Amazon Pay" deep link → "Did you use the offer? Log it to track your reward." (one-tap quick log)

SECTION 10

Success Metrics

NORTH STAR METRIC

Reward Discovery Rate (RDR)

Definition: Percentage of eligible transactions made by active RewardTrust users in which the user correctly identified the optimal payment method before transacting.

Why this is right: It measures the product's primary behavioral value — not just that users visited the app, but that the visit changed their behavior in the direction of their stated goal. An increase in RDR means users are leaving less money on the table.

Target: 35% of logged transactions use the top-recommended method (vs. ~12% baseline)

Input Metrics — Leading Indicators (Weekly Review)

Metric	Definition	Target	Why It Matters
I1 — Daily Active Lookups	Unique merchant reward lookups per day	500/day (Wk 4) · 5,000/day (Mo 3)	Primary signal that product is becoming a habitual pre-payment step
I2 — Time to First Result (TTR)	Median time from app open to first result displayed	≤ 45 seconds	Determines if RewardTrust can realistically be used in the 10-second pre-payment window
I3 — Result Quality Score (RQS)	% of results where rate data is confirmed accurate within 72h	≥ 95% at all times	One inaccurate result destroys more trust than ten low-value ones
I4 — Condition Clarity Rate	% of users who correctly answer "Does this offer apply to you?" after viewing a result	≥ 80% correct comprehension	Displaying conditions is necessary but not sufficient — they must be understood
I5 — 7-Day Retention	% of users performing ≥ 2 lookups in the 7 days following first use	40% by Month 2	Single-use visits don't create behavioral change. The habit loop requires at least two close instances.

Output Metrics — Lagging Indicators (Monthly Review)

Metric	Definition	Target
O1 — Monthly Active Users	Unique active users per month	1K (Mo 1) · 10K (Mo 3) · 50K (Mo 6)
O2 — Reward Optimization Rate	% of logged transactions where user used RewardTrust's recommended method	35% (Mo 1) · 50% (Mo 3)
O3 — Monthly Reward Value Unlocked	Est. additional reward value captured vs. pre-RewardTrust baseline	₹150/user/month additional at Mo 3
O4 — Reward Trust NPS	"How much do you trust your payment apps are rewarding you fairly?" vs. control group	+20 NPS points vs. control by Mo 3
O5 — Week-4 Retention	% of Month-1 users still active in Week 4	25% (industry benchmark: 15–20%)

Guardrail Metrics

G1 Data Accuracy Rate must stay $\geq 95\%$. Any week below 93% triggers an immediate engineering sprint. Publishing wrong data once creates disproportionate trust damage.

G2 "Misleading result" complaint rate must stay $\leq 0.5\%$ of lookups. More than 0.5% generating a complaint or correction submission triggers a data audit.

G3 Sponsored result share must stay at 0%. RewardTrust's entire value proposition rests on unbiased rankings. This is a permanent guardrail that cannot be relaxed for any revenue target.

G4 App load time at P95 must stay ≤ 3 seconds. Pre-payment use requires speed. Any P95 load time above 3 seconds makes the product unusable in the key use case.

Weekly Review Dashboard Template

Metric	Target	Actual	Status	Owner
Daily active lookups	500	—	—	Growth
Time to first result (median)	≤ 45s	—	—	Engineering
Result quality score	≥ 95%	—	—	Data
7-day retention	40%	—	—	Product
Data accuracy rate	≥ 95%	—	—	Data
Complaint rate	≤ 0.5%	—	—	Product
New users this week	200	—	—	Growth

SECTION 11

MVP Scope

The MVP solves exactly one trust gap: **Gap 1 — Anticipation**. "Will I get a reward? How much?" It must: (1) solve the single most painful trust gap at sufficient quality to be genuinely useful, (2) be buildable in four weeks by 2–3 engineers, (3) generate sufficient user feedback to validate next-phase investment, and (4) be portfolio-demonstrable.

What Is in the MVP

Feature	Scope
Merchant Reward Lookup	Search + top-20 quick-selects, amount entry, ranked rupee results, top recommendation highlighted, conditions inline, no account required
Basic Payment Method Profile	Optional — user saves cards/apps; personalized results; stored locally (no server-side account in MVP)
Reward Rate Database — Static V1	20 merchants × 8 payment methods = 160 rate entries; manually curated; updated weekly; structured for Phase 2 automation
Share Result	One-tap share of comparison as image or link; primary growth mechanism
Suggest a Merchant	Simple form to request uncovered merchants; powered by Google Form/Typeform in MVP; primary demand signal

MVP 4-Week Build Plan

Week	Focus	Deliverables
Week 1	Foundation	React web app setup, reward rate JSON database (160 entries), search + amount entry UI, basic result display
Week 2	Core Experience	Ranked results UI with rupee amounts, conditions display component, quick-select chips, top recommendation highlight, local-storage payment profile
Week 3	Polish & Trust	Data freshness indicator, suggest-a-merchant flow, share functionality, basic onboarding, mobile-responsive design, performance optimization (<2s load)
Week 4	Launch & Seed	Deploy to Vercel, post in r/IndiaFinance & r/CreditCardsIndia, PM case study documentation, PostHog/Mixpanel analytics, first 50 user feedback responses

MVP Success Criteria — 4-Week Checkpoint

Metric	Target
Total users in Week 1	500+
Lookups performed	2,000+
Return visit rate (used more than once)	30%+
"Share" clicks per day	20+
Merchant suggestions submitted	50+
Confirmed inaccuracy reports	0
NPS from 20+ user survey responses	50+

MVP Technology Stack

Component	Choice	Reason
Frontend	React + Vite	Fast development, component reusability, excellent community
Hosting	Vercel	Free tier, instant deploys from GitHub, excellent performance
Database (MVP)	JSON flat files in repository	Zero infrastructure, instant iteration, no backend needed
Database (Phase 2)	Supabase (PostgreSQL)	Free tier, real-time capabilities, easy migration from JSON
Analytics	PostHog (self-hosted)	Free, privacy-first, full funnel analysis
Error tracking	Sentry free tier	Essential for data accuracy monitoring

SECTION 12

Technical Architecture

MVP Architecture (Weeks 1–4)

A static React application with reward rate data stored as JSON files in the repository. No backend, no database, no authentication.



Key architectural decision — calculation engine: The reward calculation logic is isolated in `calculateReward.js` from day one. This enables (a) unit testing of all reward calculation rules, (b) easy swapping of data source from JSON to API in Phase 2, and (c) reuse in a potential React Native app.

Data Pipeline Architecture

Phase	Approach	Update Frequency
MVP	Manual data entry — team member visits each T&C page, updates JSON, deploys	Weekly
Phase 2	Automated extraction from official T&C URLs via daily scraping; rate changes trigger Slack alert for human review before deployment	Daily automated, human-reviewed
Phase 3	API partnerships with payment companies for real-time rate access	Real-time

Data Accuracy Protocol

Every rate entry in the database includes a structured verification record:

```
{
  "method": "amazon-pay-icici",
  "merchant_id": "swiggy",
  "rate": 0.05,
  "type": "cashback",
  "currency": "INR",
  "conditions": [...],
  "cap_amount": null,
  "last_verified_date": "2026-06-10",
  "source_url": "https:// ...",
  "verified_by": "PM-review",
  "confidence": "high"
}
```

SECTION 13

Dependencies and Risks

Dependencies

D1 — Data accuracy (Critical): The entire product rests on accurate reward rate data. This is a continuous operational dependency. A single high-profile inaccuracy — user takes out Amazon Pay ICICI to earn ₹47, earns ₹0 because rate changed — can damage product trust irreparably.

Mitigation: Build accuracy monitoring before acquiring large user volumes. Rate data is double-verified before publication.

D2 — Payment company T&C accessibility: Reward rates are publicly available, but pages are not always machine-readable. Manual extraction is labor-intensive at scale. *Mitigation:* Start with top 20 merchants where rate information is most clearly published. Build data entry tooling that makes updates efficient. Long-term: pursue API partnerships.

D3 — Rate change frequency: Banks change annual reward rates; CRED changes promotional rates regularly; daily deals can change constantly. *Mitigation:* Distinguish (a) permanent base rates, (b) promotional rates, (c) daily deals. Don't attempt to cover what cannot be maintained accurately.

Risks

R1 · HIGH PROBABILITY / HIGH IMPACT

Data Inaccuracy Causing User Harm

A user relies on RewardTrust, makes a payment expecting ₹47 cashback, and earns ₹0 because the rate was outdated or a condition was missed.

Mitigation: Always display data freshness. Always display all conditions prominently. Caveat high-value results. Build "Was this accurate?" one-tap feedback on every result.

R2 · LOW PROBABILITY / HIGH IMPACT

Payment Company Cease-and-Desist

A payment company objects to RewardTrust publishing their reward rates and requests removal.

Mitigation: Display rates as factual data, always cite source. No logos or branded visuals without permission. Build relationships proactively — the product makes their rewards more discoverable and effective.

R3 · MEDIUM PROBABILITY / MEDIUM IMPACT

Commoditization by Incumbents

PhonePe, GPay, or Amazon Pay builds the reward comparison feature natively.

Mitigation: A single-incumbent solution doesn't solve the cross-app comparison need. RewardTrust's neutrality is the defensible position. Move toward B2B API model where incumbents become partners, not competitors.

R4 · MEDIUM PROBABILITY / MEDIUM IMPACT**Low User Acquisition**

The product solves a real problem but users don't know it exists, or don't think about it until after they've already paid.

Mitigation: Focus on communities where the problem is actively discussed (r/IndiaFinance, r/CreditCardsIndia). Build for shareability — reward comparison cards create organic distribution. Consider personal finance YouTube influencer partnerships.

SECTION 14

Future Roadmap

Each phase is structured as a validated learning cycle, not a pre-committed feature list. Phase N+1 scope is confirmed only after Phase N metrics are validated.

PHASE 1 · WEEKS 1–4

MVP: Pre-Transaction Transparency

Prove the core value proposition in the simplest possible form.

SUCCESS CRITERIA TO UNLOCK PHASE 2

- 500+ MAU at end of Week 4
- 30%+ return visit rate
- NPS $\geq$ 50 from early users
- Reward Optimization Rate $\geq$ 25% in logged transactions
- Zero confirmed data accuracy failures

KEY LEARNING QUESTIONS

- Do users use RewardTrust in-the-moment or only when researching retrospectively?
- Which merchants generate the most lookups?
- What is the most common reason users don't use the top recommendation?

PHASE 2 · MONTHS 2–4

Trust Completion: Post-Transaction Layer

Close the reward loop — from pre-transaction to post-transaction confirmation.

CORE ADDITIONS

- **Transaction Logging & Reward Verification** — "Why didn't I get a reward?" feature; high-pain, high-trust-impact
- **Reward Status Tracker** — dashboard of all logged transactions with reward status and expected credit dates
- **User Accounts** — lightweight; prompted after third use (engagement threshold), not at first launch
- **Coverage Expansion** — 20 → 50 merchants, 4 additional payment methods based on Phase 1 data

SUCCESS CRITERIA TO UNLOCK PHASE 3

- 5,000+ MAU · 40%+ users have logged ≥ 1 transaction · +20 NPS vs. control · 30%+ Week-4 retention

PHASE 3 · MONTHS 4–9

Intelligence Layer: Proactive and Personalized

Stop asking users to come to RewardTrust. Bring RewardTrust to the user at the exact moment of need.

CORE ADDITIONS

- **Push Notification Alerts** — high-value offers at followed merchants within offer validity window
- **Reward Rate Change Alerts** — Pro users notified within 24h of confirmed rate change, with monthly spend impact estimate
- **Monthly Reward Report** — "You earned ₹X. You could have earned ₹Y. Here's the one change that would have made the biggest difference."
- **Pro Tier Launch (₹99/month)** — push alerts, rate change notifications, monthly reports, optimization analysis, CSV export

PHASE 4 · MONTHS 9–18

Platform: API and B2B Infrastructure

Become the reward transparency infrastructure that other products are built on.

B2B PRODUCTS

- **RewardTrust API** — real-time reward rate data API; white-label comparison widget; post-transaction explanation API. Pricing: tiered by volume, starting ₹5,000/month
- **RewardTrust Trust Score** — standardized scoring of payment products on reward reliability, rate stability, and delivery performance. Licensed to comparison sites, media, and fintech research. The "Trustpilot for reward programs" in India.

STRATEGIC LOGIC

By Phase 4, RewardTrust will have the most accurate, comprehensive, real-time reward rate database in India, a proven consumer product, and 50,000+ active users. This credibility creates a B2B opportunity that incumbent payment companies — for whom reward data infrastructure is non-core — will pay for.

18-Month Metric Targets

Metric	Month 1	Month 3	Month 6	Month 12	Month 18
Monthly Active Users	1,000	10,000	50,000	200,000	500,000
Daily Lookups	500	5,000	25,000	100,000	300,000
Data accuracy rate	97%	98%	99%	99%+	99%+
Week-4 retention	20%	30%	35%	40%	45%
Pro conversion (of MAU)	—	—	—	5%	8%
B2B API partners	—	—	—	2	8
Monthly recurring revenue	₹0	₹0	₹0	₹10L	₹40L

The 3-year vision: RewardTrust becomes the standard trust infrastructure for Indian payment rewards — the entity whose data and ratings determine whether a payment product's rewards are perceived as trustworthy by the market.

APPENDIX A

Design Principles

- **Show rupees, not percentages**

A user deciding between payment options at a point of sale needs "₹22 vs ₹4.50" — not "5% vs 1%." Percentages require arithmetic. Rupees require none. Every result is in rupees.

- **Show all conditions before the decision, not after**

A user who discovers a condition they don't meet after committing to a payment method has been failed by the product. Every condition is shown in the results, not in a modal requiring a separate click.

- **Never promise more than can be delivered**

If a rate is uncertain, say so. If data is potentially stale, say so. The product's entire value is trust — overpromising destroys it faster than any competitor.

- **Design for the 45-second window**

The use case is: user is about to pay, has 45 seconds before the merchant expects them to be done. Every interaction must be completable in that window. If it takes longer, it will be abandoned.

- **Accuracy over coverage**

It is better to accurately cover 20 merchants than to inaccurately cover 100. We do not publish data we cannot verify. We do not expand coverage faster than we can maintain accuracy.

APPENDIX B

Open Questions for Phase I Validation

- 1 Do users actually use RewardTrust in-the-moment, or primarily when researching retrospectively? (Determines whether UX should optimize for speed or depth.)

- 2 What is the primary barrier to using the top recommendation — "I don't have that card," "I don't trust the data is accurate," or "the effort of switching apps isn't worth ₹17"? (Each has a different solution.)

- 3 At what reward differential do users actually change their payment method? ₹5? ₹20? ₹100? (Determines the value of covering many merchants vs. fewer with higher differentials.)

- 4 Do users who experience reward regret (finding a better option after paying) become more engaged RewardTrust users, or do they give up? (Determines whether post-payment flows are a retention mechanism or a frustration amplifier.)

- 5 What is the primary use case by merchant category — food delivery, fuel, or utilities? (Determines which category to deepen first in Phase 2.)
